

combat sports, still carries a left hook capable of ending fights in an instant. His arsenal of kicks and pressure can tilt the tempo if the bout stays upright. The vulnerability, however, remains clear: when the takedown threat looms, his defensive options narrow.

For Ankalaev, the path is familiar: wrestle, control, repeat. For Pereira, survival hinges on denying that rhythm long enough to impose his own weapons. **This is not just striker versus grappler. It is a contest of who can claim their preferred battleground first.**

The bantamweight co-main brings another clash of contrasts. Champion Merab “The Machine”

Dvalishvili thrives on non-stop pressure, overwhelming opponents with chain wrestling and constant motion. His goal is not the single takedown, but the cumulative weight of attempts that eventually grind opponents down.

Opposite him is Cory “The Sandman” Sandhagen, one of the division’s most inventive strikers. His unorthodox footwork, spinning strikes, and ability to create openings from odd angles make him a puzzle few can solve. If he maintains distance, he dictates terms; if Dvalishvili traps him against the fence, the champion’s grind takes over.



Did you know?

UFC history took a sharp turn in 2013 thanks to Ronda Rousey (left).

For years, Dana White insisted women would never fight in the UFC. Rousey’s dominance and star power forced a change of mind, making her the first woman to sign with the promotion. Her run of armbar finishes drew a new wave of fans and proved the value of women’s MMA. In 2022, she became the first woman inducted into the UFC Hall of Fame. Her impact is a reminder that fighters who bring something different — be it Rousey’s pioneering presence, Ankalaev’s suffocating control, or Pereira and Sandhagen’s striking artistry — often reshape the sport itself.

